- Madubhan Copper Plate Inscription (Punjab)
- Sonpat Copper Plate
- Nalanda Inscription on clay seal

Literary Sources

- *Vishnu, Matsya, Vayu* and *Bhagavata* Puranas and *Niti Sastras* of Narada
- Visakhadatta's *Devichandraguptam* and *Mudrarakshasa* and Bana's *Harshacharita*
- Dramas of Kalidasa
- Accounts of Chinese Buddhist monk Fahien who visited India during the reign of Chandragupta II.
- Harsha's *Ratnavali, Nagananda, Priyadharshika*
- Hiuen-Tsang's Si-Yu-Ki

Foundation of the Gupta Dynasty

Sri Gupta is considered to be the founder of the Gupta dynasty. He is believed to have reigned over parts of present-day Bengal and Bihar. He was the first Gupta ruler to be featured on coins. He was succeeded by his son Ghatotkacha. Both are mentioned as Maharajas in inscriptions.

Chandragupta I (319–335 AD(CE))

Chandragupta I married Kumaradevi of the famous and powerful Lichchhavi family. Having gained the support of this family, Chandragupta could eliminate various small states in northern India and crown himself the monarch of a larger kingdom. The gold coins attributed to Chandragupta bear the images of Chandragupta, Kumaradevi and the legend 'Lichchhavayah'.

Lichchhavi was an old gana–sanga and its territory lay between the Ganges and the Nepal Terai.

Samudragupta (335–380 AD(CE))

Samudragupta, son of Chandragupta I, was the greatest ruler of the dynasty. The Prayog Prashasti, composed by Samudragupta's court poet Harisena was engraved on Allahabad Pillar. This Allahabad Pillar inscription is the main source of information for Samudragupta's reign.



Allahabad Pillar

Prashasti

Prashasti is a Sanskrit word, meaning commendation or 'in praise of'. Court poets flattered their kings listing out their achievements. These accounts were later engraved on pillars so that the people could read them.

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